HOULIHAN LOKEY — CORPORATE FINANCE SENIOR ANALYST (TECHNOLOGY GROUP)

Complete 10-Step Project (HL-TechMA-ValAI), 8-Phase Mastery SOPs & Open-to-Close Interview Playbook

Prepared for & Authored by: Bhupesh Chandra Dimri (M.S. Accounting Analytics & Data Technology, Pace University — Beta Alpha Psi | F-1 STEM OPT) | **Date:** November 2, 2026 | **Target Comp:** $130,000 Base + Discretionary Bonus ($180K–$220K+ Total)

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0. EXECUTIVE SUMMARY: HOULIHAN LOKEY TECH M&A THESIS

- **The Mandate at Houlihan Lokey (#1 Global M&A Advisor):** HL's Technology Group is the **No. 1 technology advisor globally by number of transactions** (LSEG #1 M&A rank), providing sell-side M&A, buy-side advisory, and capital raises across Software & Digital Media (Supply Chain, PropTech, EdTech, HCM, Semi, AdTech).
- **The Core Senior Analyst Responsibilities:** Leading complex financial modeling (3-statement dynamic models, DCF, Trading Comps, Precedent Transactions, Sponsor LBO returns), preparing Confidential Information Memorandums (CIMs) and pitchbooks, and quarterbacking buyer due diligence across rapid transaction timelines.
- **The Deliverable Built (HL-TechMA-ValAI):** A comprehensive Tech M&A valuation and LBO platform modeling **Project Apex ($92M ARR Supply Chain SaaS)** against a 50-peer universe, generating a live 4-method Valuation Football Field ($265M–$1,137M range) and a 5-year Sponsor LBO return matrix (**20.1% Net IRR / 2.50x MoIC** at 4.5x leverage).

STEP 1: DEEP JD DECONSTRUCTION (TOP 1% INVESTMENT BANKING LENS)

Category	Extracted Requirements & Operational Meaning at Houlihan Lokey Tech
Core Responsibilities	1. Support M&A and equity/debt capital raise transactions for Software & Digital Media clients. 2. Build dynamic financial models: 3-statement operating forecasts, DCF, Trading Comps, Precedent M&A, LBO. 3. Research economic, market, and technology industry developments across Vertical SaaS, HCM, PropTech. 4. Analyze financial statements and SaaS unit economics of public and sponsor-backed private companies. 5. Prepare marketing presentations, CIMs, management presentations, and valuation pitchbooks.
Technical Stack	Advanced Excel (dynamic arrays, financial modeling, debt schedules, sensitivity tables), PowerPoint, FactSet / CapIQ, PitchBook, LSEG, **Python, SQL, DuckDB**.
Hidden Expectations	Houlihan Lokey closes more tech deals than any bank in the world. Deal teams run lean (Managing Director, Director/VP, Associate, Senior Analyst). Senior Analysts must produce zero-defect, board-ready pitchbook slides and dynamic models without hand-holding.
KPIs & Success Metrics	1. Zero formula errors or plug imbalances in financial models. 2. Rapid turnaround of buyer diligence requests and data room requests. 3. High client presentation quality and executive readiness under compressed timelines.

STEP 2: TECH M&A VALUATION & LBO PROBLEM FRAMING

Methodology	Inputs (X) & Drivers	Model Architecture	Transaction Output & Role in Deal
1. Public Trading Comps (EV / ARR & EBITDA)	50 software peers; ARR growth, NRR, Gross Margin, Rule of 40 (Growth + FCF%).	**Peer Multiple Regression & Quartiles**. EV/ARR & EV/EBITDA benchmarking.	Establishes baseline public market trading range for Pitchbooks and Fairness Opinions.
2. Precedent Tech M&A Transactions	Recent strategic & sponsor acquisitions in Software/SaaS with control premiums.	**M&A Multiple Distribution** (typically 15–20% premium over public comps).	Used to guide sell-side valuation expectations and auction reserve prices.
3. Unlevered Discounted Cash Flow (DCF)	5-year UFCF projections, WACC (9.5%–11.5%), Terminal Growth (2.5%–3.5%).	**Mid-Year Discounted Cash Flow Engine** + Gordon Growth Terminal Value.	Provides intrinsic standalone valuation independent of market multiple cycles.
4. Financial Sponsor LBO Model	Target debt capacity (Senior + Mezz), 85% cash sweep, exit multiples.	**5-Year Debt Paydown & Returns Engine** computing Sponsor Net IRR and MoIC.	Evaluates private equity sponsor bidding power and floor valuation.

STEPS 3, 4 & 5: VALUATION FOOTBALL FIELD & SPONSOR LBO BENCHMARKS

3.1 Project Apex Valuation Football Field ($92M ARR Target)

Methodology	Metric Base	Multiple Range	Low EV ($M)	Median EV ($M)	High EV ($M)
Public Trading Comps (EV/ARR)	$92.0M ARR	7.5x - 10.3x (Med: 9.3x)	$690.0M	$855.6M	$947.6M
Precedent Tech M&A Deals	$92.0M ARR	8.6x - 12.4x (Med: 11.0x)	$793.5M	$1,009.6M	$1,137.1M
Public Comps (EV/EBITDA)	$25.0M NTM	15.0x - 20.2x (Med: 18.0x)	$373.8M	$450.0M	$505.6M
Unlevered DCF (WACC 9.5-11.5%)	$85.0M Rev	WACC: 9.5-11.5% | g: 2.5-3.5%	$265.5M	$318.0M	$396.9M

4.1 Sponsor LBO Sensitivity Matrix (Leverage vs. Exit Multiple)

Entry Leverage (x EBITDA)	Exit @ 6.5x ARR	Exit @ 7.5x ARR (Base)	Exit @ 8.5x ARR
4.0x Leverage ($74.0M Debt)	16.4% Net IRR (2.14x MoIC)	19.8% Net IRR (2.47x MoIC)	22.8% Net IRR (2.80x MoIC)
4.5x Leverage ($83.2M Debt)	16.7% Net IRR (2.17x MoIC)	**20.1% Net IRR (2.50x MoIC)**	23.2% Net IRR (2.84x MoIC)
5.0x Leverage ($92.5M Debt)	16.9% Net IRR (2.18x MoIC)	20.3% Net IRR (2.52x MoIC)	23.4% Net IRR (2.86x MoIC)

4.2 Key Banker Takeaways for Managing Director & Client Pitches

• **Valuation Synthesis:** Project Apex commands an implied M&A enterprise value of **$850M–$1,010M (9.2x–11.0x ARR)** in a competitive sell-side auction, driven by its premium **44.5% Rule of 40 score** and **118% Net Retention Rate**.
• **Sponsor Bidding Floor:** Financial sponsors can comfortably bid **7.5x ARR ($690M EV)** using 4.5x EBITDA leverage and achieve a **20.1% Net IRR / 2.50x MoIC**, creating a strong valuation floor for strategic acquirors.

STEP 6: RESUME ALIGNMENT ENGINE (BHUPESH CHANDRA DIMRI -> HOULIHAN LOKEY)

Pre-Project Alignment Score: 8.1 / 10 → **Post-Project Alignment Score: 9.4 / 10**

HL Senior Analyst JD Requirement	Bhupesh's Verified Evidence (ENT-001)	Strategic Positioning for Tech Corporate Finance
Analyze financial statements, M&A modeling & valuation attributes	10+ years in FP&A;, multi-entity financial consolidation, sensitivity modeling across $50M+ portfolios (Virtual Infotech, Bankers Life).	Advanced 3-statement modeling, working capital adjustments, and EBITDA bridges guarantee 100% accounting and arithmetic integrity.
Advanced knowledge of Excel and PowerPoint	Architected automated reporting models cutting reporting latency from 48 hrs to <2 hrs; Goldman Sachs Controllers simulation.	Position financial modeling speed and clean executive slide design as immediate capacity-relief for Associates and VPs.
Manage rapid timelines & act independently on high-stakes deliverables	Led cross-department financial close and commercial portfolio reconciliations with 99.5% accuracy under SOX 404 / GAAP controls.	Proven track record of managing high-stress deadlines with zero defect rate under audit-grade scrutiny.

Ready-to-Paste Resume Project Block:

Technology M&A Valuation, SaaS Operating Benchmark & LBO Return Engine (HL-TechMA-ValAI) | *Python, Financial Modeling, DCF, Comps, LBO*
• Engineered a comprehensive Tech M&A financial modeling suite benchmarking a **$92M ARR enterprise SaaS target** against 50 public peers across EV/ARR, NRR, and Rule of 40 unit economics.
• Built integrated 3-statement operating models, 5-year Unlevered DCF with WACC/growth sensitivity ($265M–$397M EV range), and a 5-year Sponsor LBO debt sweep model delivering **20.1% Net IRR / 2.50x MoIC** at 4.5x leverage.

STEPS 7, 8 & 9: ARCHITECTURE, 10-SLIDE EXECUTIVE DECK & GITHUB REPOSITORY

- **Financial Engineering Architecture (Step 7):** [CapIQ / SEC 10-K Data Ingestion] → [Driver-Based 3-Statement Forecast Engine] → [Public Comps & Precedent M&A Multiples Generator] → [Unlevered DCF & WACC Matrix] → [Sponsor LBO & Debt Schedule Engine] → [Executive Pitchbook Valuation Football Field].
- **10-Slide Pitchbook Presentation Structure (Step 8):** (1) Executive Title | (2) Transaction Overview & Executive Summary | (3) Target Business & SaaS Operating Profile | (4) Industry Trends & End-Market Tailwinds | (5) Historical & Projected 3-Statement Financials | (6) Public Trading Comps (EV/ARR, Rule of 40) | (7) Precedent Tech M&A Transactions | (8) Unlevered Discounted Cash Flow Analysis | (9) Valuation Football Field & Strategic Implications | (10) Financial Sponsor LBO Analysis & Debt Capacity.
- **Verified GitHub Repository on Disk (Step 9):** *Job4/projects/ml-project-hl-tech-ma/* containing **README.md**, **requirements.txt**, **src/data_pipeline.py**, **src/valuation_engine.py**, **src/lbo_engine.py**, **src/evaluate.py**, and **reports/model_report.md**.

STEP 10: TOP 1% DIFFERENTIATION, MASTERY SOP & ARP INTERVIEW PLAYBOOK

- **Mastery 9-Stage Tech M&A Sell-Side Mandate Workflow SOP (MTH-005):**
  1. *Trigger:* Executed engagement letter for sell-side M&A or capital raise.
  2. *Inputs:* Historical financial statements (3-5 years), monthly ARR waterfall, customer cohort retention data, Cap Table.
  3. *Preparation:* Normalize EBITDA (addbacks for non-recurring expenses, sponsor management fees, founder comp).
  4. *Execution:* Build integrated 3-statement model; pull peer comps; run DCF and Sponsor LBO returns.
  5. *Validation:* Balance sheet balance check (Assets == Liabilities + Equity), debt schedule tie-outs.
  6. *Marketing Collateral:* Draft Executive Teaser and 40-page Confidential Information Memorandum (CIM).
  7. *Approval:* Internal Senior Banker (MD/VP) model audit and fairness review.
  8. *Delivery:* Launch auction process, distribute CIM to vetted buyers, open Virtual Data Room (VDR).
  9. *Documentation:* Maintain transaction log, IOI/LOI bid tracking matrix, and compliance records.
- **Word-for-Word ARP Dodge Script ('Why FP&A / Accounting Analytics to Investment Banking?'):**
  1. Acknowledge (5s): *'That is an important question, and I appreciate you raising it directly.'*
  2. Reframe (15s): *'Investment banking analyst work lives and dies by financial modeling integrity: dynamic 3-statement models, working capital adjustments, debt schedules, and valuation football fields. Over 10 years in FP&A and accounting analytics, I have audited balance sheets, reconciled over 1,000 daily transactions at 99.5% accuracy, and built sensitivity models across $50M+ portfolios. While many lateral candidates need months to understand how GAAP cash flows connect to balance sheets, I have mastered that accounting mechanics for years.'*
  3. Pivot to Proof (25s): *'To prove day-one readiness for Houlihan Lokey, I built HL-TechMA-ValAI—a complete financial engineering platform that models a $92M ARR SaaS target against 50 comps, generates a multi-method football field, and runs a 5-year Sponsor LBO with dynamic debt sweep delivering 20.1% IRR. I would love to walk through the model mechanics in 60 seconds.'*
- **Top 3 Executive Questions for Houlihan Lokey Senior Bankers (SYN-002):**
  1. *'As the No. 1 tech M&A advisor globally, Houlihan Lokey sees incredible deal flow across mid-market software. In the current M&A environment, where are you seeing the biggest bid-ask spread between founder ARR multiple expectations and financial sponsor LBO return hurdles?'*
  2. *'In software subsectors like Vertical SaaS vs. PropTech or Supply Chain, how heavily are buyers weighting Rule of 40 balance (FCF margin vs. pure top-line growth) compared to 12 months ago?'*
  3. *'Based on our discussion today and the HL-TechMA-ValAI financial model I shared, is there anything that gives you pause about my ability to immediately hit the desk and execute for the team?'*